Clinical Psychology and Psychological Disorders

1. Clinical Psychology

Clinical psychology is the branch of psychology that focuses on **understanding, diagnosing, and treating mental, emotional, and behavioural disorders**.

Clinical psychologists study how psychological problems develop and help people improve their mental health using scientific methods and therapy.

Main Goals of Clinical Psychology

1. **Assessment** – Identifying psychological problems through tests, interviews, and observations.
2. **Diagnosis** – Determining the specific psychological disorder.
3. **Treatment** – Providing therapy such as counselling or behaviour therapy.
4. **Prevention** – Helping people avoid mental health problems.
5. **Research** – Studying mental disorders and treatments.

Methods Used by Clinical Psychologists

- Psychological testing
- Clinical interviews
- Observation
- Case studies
- Psychotherapy (talking therapy)

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2. Psychological Disorders

A **psychological disorder** (mental disorder) is a **pattern of thoughts, feelings, or behaviours that causes distress and interferes with a person's daily life**.

Psychological disorders affect how a person **thinks, feels, and behaves**.

Key Features of Psychological Disorders

Psychologists often identify disorders using four common characteristics:

1. **Deviance** – Behaviour that is very different from social norms.
2. **Distress** – The person experiences significant emotional suffering.
3. **Dysfunction** – Difficulty functioning in daily life (school, work, relationships).
4. **Danger** – Behaviour that may harm the person or others.

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3. Types of Psychological Disorders

1. Anxiety Disorders

Examples:

- Phobias
- Panic disorder
- Generalised anxiety disorder

Symptoms:

- Excessive fear
- Nervousness
- Rapid heartbeat

- Avoidance behaviour

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2. Mood Disorders

Examples:

- Depression
- Bipolar disorder

Symptoms:

- Persistent sadness
- Loss of interest
- Extreme mood changes

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3. Psychotic Disorders

Example:

- Schizophrenia

Symptoms:

- Hallucinations (seeing/hearing things that are not real)
- Delusions (false beliefs)
- Disorganised thinking

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4. Eating Disorders

Examples:

- Anorexia nervosa

- Bulimia nervosa

Symptoms:

- Extreme concern about body weight
- Unhealthy eating behaviours

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5. Personality Disorders

Examples:

- Borderline personality disorder
- Antisocial personality disorder

Symptoms:

- Rigid behaviour patterns
- Difficulty in relationships

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4. Treatment of Psychological Disorders

Clinical psychologists may use different treatments such as:

- **Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT)**
- **Behaviour therapy**
- **Psychodynamic therapy**
- **Humanistic therapy**
- **Medication** (usually prescribed by psychiatrists)

✅ In simple terms:

- **Clinical psychology** = the field that studies and treats mental health problems.
- **Psychological disorders** = the mental health conditions that clinical psychologists diagnose and treat.